

“memoirs of the Apostles” to reference the four Gospels, but he never used this phrase to reference gnostic or apocryphal gospels.¹

Notice that the Gospels are mentioned first, before the ‘writings of the prophets’, that would refer to the OT. Justin makes clear that the practice of reading Scripture in the weekly meetings was continued by the Christians, and, as was to be expected, the NT writings came to be preferred. We have no evidence that the practice of reading Scripture in public meetings was ever dropped, at least in the east. Indeed, the very existence of Lectionary manuscripts would be evidence that the practice continued. If the ‘Eusebian Canons’ were actually produced by Eusebius of Caesarea (d. 339), we have evidence from the early fourth century, and he certainly was merely standardizing what was already being practiced in the churches. So then, when the Mt. Athos monks claim that their practice goes back to the earliest times, they are correct. However, **none of the above tells us what text-type was used**, and it is incumbent upon me to address that question.

But first, the lectionary evidence flatly contradicts von Soden’s claim that the system was created in Constantinople in the 12th century. According to the *Kurzgefasste Liste*² (Feb., 2018), we have one extant lectionary from the IV century, two from the V, two from the VI, two from the VII, fifteen from the VIII, 113 from the IX, 162 from the X and 303 from the XI. Even if we reduce all those numbers by half (to preclude quibble), they demonstrate that von Soden was completely mistaken. It happens that among the extant Lectionaries, the second largest family contains the **K^r/f³⁵** text, but it is small, compared to the dominant family; but please note: the difference is in the wording, not the selection of lections. Von Soden also claimed that the **K^r/f³⁵** text was imposed by ecclesiastical authority. In that event, how is it that the vast majority of Lectionaries have a different text? And how could something created in the 12th century supplant an ancient practice? Again, von Soden was completely mistaken.

It should be obvious to everyone that books that are used wear out; the more they are used, the faster they wear. The earliest manuscripts survived because no one wanted to use them; nor were they copied (why waste good parchment?). If the communities used **K^r/f³⁵** for public reading, those copies would be worn out and could not survive physically. So the lack of early **K^r/f³⁵** MSS is not necessarily an argument against the text-type.

¹ Personal communication from Dr. Michael C. Loehrer.

² Kurt Aland, ed., *Kurzgefasste Liste der Griechischen Handschriften des Neuen Testaments* (Berlin: Walter de Gruyter, 1994).